

Food and Nutrition Service, USDA

§ 273.24

these regulations. At a minimum, on-site reviews of the Simplified Application and Standardized Benefit Project shall be conducted once within six months of the project's implementation and then in accordance with the Management Evaluation review schedule for the project area.

(o) *Termination.* (1) FNS may terminate project operations for any reason and at any time on 60 days written notice to the administering State agency or political subdivision. State or local agencies may also choose to terminate their participation with 60 days written notice to FNS. In either such event, operating agencies shall be given sufficient time to return to normal operations in an orderly fashion.

(2) If termination occurs, FNS may select another site for project operations. Such selection shall be based on either previously received project proposals or proposals received under a new solicitation.

[53 FR 26224, July 12, 1988]

§ 273.24 Time limit for able-bodied adults.

(a) *Definitions.* For purposes of the SNAP time limit, the terms below have the following meanings:

(1) *Fulfilling the work requirement* means:

(i) Working 20 hours per week, averaged monthly; for purposes of this provision, 20 hours a week averaged monthly means 80 hours a month;

(ii) Participating in and complying with the requirements of a work program 20 hours per week, as determined by the State agency;

(iii) Any combination of working and participating in a work program for a total of 20 hours per week, as determined by the State agency; or

(iv) Participating in and complying with a workfare program;

(2) *Working* means:

(i) Work in exchange for money;

(ii) Work in exchange for goods or services ("in kind" work); or

(iii) Unpaid work, verified under standards established by the State agency.

(iv) Any combination of paragraphs (a)(2)(i), (a)(2)(ii) and (a)(2)(iii) of this section.

(3) *Work Program* means:

(i) A program under title 1 of the Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA) (Pub. L.113-128);

(ii) A program under section 236 of the Trade Act of 1974 (19 U.S.C. 2296);

(iii) An employment and training program operated or supervised by a State or political subdivision of a State agency that meets standards approved by the Chief Executive Office, including a SNAP E&T program under § 273.7(e) excluding any job search, supervised job search, or job search training program. However, a program under this clause may contain job search, supervised job search, or job search training as subsidiary activities as long as such activity is less than half the requirement. Participation in job search, supervised job search, or job search training as subsidiary activities that make up less than half the requirement counts for purposes of fulfilling the work requirement under paragraph (a)(1)(ii) of this section.

(iv) A program of employment and training for veterans operated by the Department of Labor or the Department of Veterans Affairs. For the purpose of this paragraph, any employment and training program of the Department of Labor or Veterans Affairs that serves veterans shall be an approved work program; or

(v) A workforce partnership under § 273.7(n)

(b) *General Rule.* Individuals are not eligible to participate in SNAP as a member of any household if the individual received SNAP benefits for more than three countable months during any three-year period, except that individuals may be eligible for up to three additional countable months in accordance with paragraph (e) of this section.

(1) *Countable months.* Countable months are months during which an individual receives SNAP benefits for the full benefit month while not:

(i) Exempt under paragraph (c) of this section;

(ii) Covered by a waiver under paragraph (f) of this section;

(iii) Fulfilling the work requirement as defined in paragraph (a)(1) of this section;

(iv) Receiving benefits that are prorated in accordance with § 273.10; or

§ 273.24

7 CFR Ch. II (1–1–25 Edition)

(v) In the month of notification from the State agency of a provider determination in accordance with § 273.7(c)(18)(i).

(2) *Good cause.* As determined by the State agency, if an individual would have fulfilled the work requirement as defined in paragraph (a)(1) of this section, but missed some hours for good cause, the individual shall be considered to have fulfilled the work requirement if the absence from work, the work program, or the workfare program is temporary. Good cause shall include circumstances beyond the individual's control, such as, but not limited to, illness, illness of another household member requiring the presence of the member, a household emergency, or the unavailability of transportation. In addition, if the State agency grants an individual good cause under § 273.7(i) for failure or refusal to meet the mandatory E&T requirement, that good cause determination confers good cause under this paragraph, except in the case of § 273.7(i)(4), without the need for a separate good cause determination under this paragraph. Good cause granted under § 273.7(i)(4) only provides good cause to ABAWDs for failure or refusal to participate in a mandatory SNAP E&T program, and does not confer good cause for failure to fulfill the work requirement in paragraph (a)(1) of this section.

(3) *Measuring the three-year period.* The State agency may measure and track the three-year period as it deems appropriate. The State agency may use either a “fixed” or “rolling” clock. If the State agency chooses to switch tracking methods it must inform FNS in writing. With respect to a State, the three-year period:

(i) Shall be measured and tracked consistently so that individuals who are similarly situated are treated the same; and

(ii) Shall not include any period before the earlier of November 22, 1996, or the date the State notified SNAP recipients of the application of Section 824 of the Personal Responsibility and Work Opportunity Reconciliation Act of 1996 (Pub. L. 104–193).

(4) *Treatment of income and resources.* The income and resources of an individual made ineligible under this para-

graph (b) shall be handled in accordance with § 273.11(c)(2).

(5) *Benefits received erroneously.* If an individual subject to this section receives SNAP benefits erroneously, the State agency shall consider the benefits to have been received for purposes of this provision unless or until the individual pays it back in full.

(6) *Verification.* Verification shall be in accordance with § 273.2(f)(1) and (f)(8).

(7) *Reporting.* A change in work hours below 20 hours per week, averaged monthly, is a reportable change in accordance with § 273.12(a)(1)(viii). Regardless of the type of reporting system the State agency assigns to potential ABAWDs, the State agency must adhere to the statutory requirements of time-limited benefits for individuals who are subject to the work requirement. The State agency may opt to consider work performed in a job that was not reported according to the requirements of § 273.12 “work.”

(8) The State agency shall inform all ABAWDs of the ABAWD work requirement and time limit both in writing and orally in accordance with § 273.7(c)(1)(ii) and (iii).

(c) *Exceptions.* The time limit does not apply to an individual if he or she is:

(1) Under 18 or 50 years of age or older;

(2) Determined by the State agency to be medically certified as physically or mentally unfit for employment. An individual is medically certified as physically or mentally unfit for employment if he or she:

(i) Is receiving temporary or permanent disability benefits issued by governmental or private sources;

(ii) Is obviously mentally or physically unfit for employment as determined by the State agency; or

(iii) If the unfitness is not obvious, provides a statement from a physician, physician's assistant, nurse, nurse practitioner, designated representative of the physician's office, a licensed or certified psychologist, a social worker, or any other medical personnel the State agency determines appropriate, that he or she is physically or mentally unfit for employment.

Food and Nutrition Service, USDA

§ 273.24

(3) Is a parent (natural, adoptive, or step) of a household member under age 18, even if the household member who is under 18 is not himself eligible for SNAP benefits;

(4) Is residing in a household where a household member is under age 18, even if the household member who is under 18 is not himself eligible for SNAP benefits;

(5) Is otherwise exempt from work requirements under section 6(d)(2) of the Food and Nutrition Act of 2008, as implemented in regulations at § 273.7(b); or

(6) Is pregnant.

(d) *Regaining eligibility.* (1) An individual denied eligibility under paragraph (b) of this section, or who did not reapply for benefits because he was not meeting the work requirements under paragraph (b) of this section, shall regain eligibility to participate in SNAP if, as determined by the State agency, during any 30 consecutive days, he or she:

(i) Worked 80 or more hours;

(ii) Participated in and complied with the requirements of a work program for 80 or more hours;

(iii) Any combination of work and participation in a work program for a total of 80 hours; or participated in and complied with a workfare program; or

(iv) At State agency option, verifies that the he or she will meet one of the requirements in paragraphs (d)(1)(i), (d)(1)(ii), (d)(1)(iii), or (d)(1)(v) of this section, within the 30 days subsequent to application; or

(v) Becomes exempt.

(2) An individual regaining eligibility under paragraph (d)(1) of this section shall have benefits calculated as follows:

(i) For individuals regaining eligibility by working, participating in a work program, or combining hours worked and hours participating in a work program, the State agency may either prorate benefits from the day the 80 hours are completed or from the date of application, or

(ii) For individuals regaining eligibility by participating in a workfare program, and the workfare obligation is based on an estimated monthly allotment prorated back to the date of

application, then the allotment issued must be prorated back to this date.

(3) There is no limit on how many times an individual may regain eligibility and subsequently maintain eligibility by meeting the work requirement.

(e) *Additional three-month eligibility.* An individual who regained eligibility under paragraph (d) of this section and who is no longer fulfilling the work requirement as defined in paragraph (a) of this section is eligible for a period of three consecutive countable months (as defined in paragraph (b) of this section), starting on the date the individual first notifies the State agency that he or she is no longer fulfilling the work requirement, unless the individual has been satisfying the work requirement by participating in a work or workfare program, in which case the period starts on the date the State agency notifies the individual that he or she is no longer meeting the work requirement. An individual shall not receive benefits under this paragraph (e) more than once in any three-year period.

(f) *Waivers*—(1) *General.* On the request of a State agency, FNS may waive the time limit for a group of individuals in the State if we determine that the area in which the individuals reside:

(i) Has an unemployment rate of over 10 percent; or

(ii) Does not have a sufficient number of jobs to provide employment for the individuals.

(2) *Required data.* The State agency may submit whatever data it deems appropriate to support its request. However, to support waiver requests based on unemployment rates or labor force data, States must submit data that relies on standard Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) data or methods. A non-exhaustive list of the kinds of data a State agency may submit follows:

(i) To support a claim of unemployment over 10 percent, a State agency may submit evidence that an area has a recent 12 month average unemployment rate over 10 percent; a recent three month average unemployment rate over 10 percent; or an historical seasonal unemployment rate over 10 percent; or

(ii) To support a claim of lack of sufficient jobs, a State may submit evidence that an area: Is designated as a Labor Surplus Area (LSA) by the Department of Labor's Employment and Training Administration (ETA); is determined by the Department of Labor's Unemployment Insurance Service as qualifying for extended unemployment benefits; has a low and declining employment-to-population ratio; has a lack of jobs in declining occupations or industries; is described in an academic study or other publications as an area where there are lack of jobs; has a 24-month average unemployment rate 20 percent above the national average for the same 24-month period. This 24-month period may not be any earlier than the same 24-month period the ETA uses to designate LSAs for the current fiscal year.

(3) *Waivers that are readily approvable.* FNS will approve State agency waivers where FNS confirms:

(i) Data from the BLS or the BLS cooperating agency that shows an area has a most recent 12 month average unemployment rate over 10 percent;

(ii) Evidence that the area has been designated a Labor Surplus Area by the ETA for the current fiscal year; or

(iii) Data from the BLS or the BLS cooperating agency that an area has a 24 month average unemployment rate that exceeds the national average by 20 percent for any 24-month period no earlier than the same period the ETA uses to designate LSAs for the current fiscal year.

(4) *Effective date of certain waivers.* In areas for which the State certifies that data from the BLS or the BLS cooperating agency show a most recent 12 month average unemployment rate over 10 percent; or the area has been designated as a Labor Surplus Area by the Department of Labor's Employment and Training Administration for the current fiscal year, the State may begin to operate the waiver at the time the waiver request is submitted. FNS will contact the State if the waiver must be modified.

(5) *Duration of waiver.* In general, waivers will be approved for one year. The duration of a waiver should bear some relationship to the documentation provided in support of the waiver

request. FNS will consider approving waivers for up to one year based on documentation covering a shorter period, but the State agency must show that the basis for the waiver is not a seasonal or short term aberration. We reserve the right to approve waivers for a shorter period at the State agency's request or if the data is insufficient. We reserve the right to approve a waiver for a longer period if the reasons are compelling.

(6) *Areas covered by waivers.* States may define areas to be covered by waivers. We encourage State agencies to submit data and analyses that correspond to the defined area. If corresponding data does not exist, State agencies should submit data that corresponds as closely to the area as possible.

(g) *Discretionary exemptions.* (1) For the purpose of establishing the discretionary exemptions for each State agency, the following terms are defined:

(i) *Caseload* means the average monthly number of individuals receiving SNAP benefits during the 12-month period ending the preceding June 30.

(ii) *Covered individual* means a SNAP recipient, or an applicant denied eligibility for benefits solely because he or she received SNAP benefits during the 3 months of eligibility provided under paragraph (b) of this section, who:

(A) Is not exempt from the time limit under paragraph (c) of this section;

(B) Does not reside in an area covered by a waiver granted under paragraph (f) of this section;

(C) Is not fulfilling the work requirements as defined in paragraph (a)(1) of this section; and

(D) Is not receiving SNAP benefits under paragraph (e) of this section.

(2) Subject to paragraphs (h) and (i) of this section, a State agency may provide an exemption from the 3-month time limit of paragraph (b) of this section for covered individuals. Exemptions do not count towards a State agency's allocation if they are provided to an individual who is otherwise exempt from the time limit during that month.

(3) For each fiscal year, a State agency may provide a number of exemptions such that the average monthly

Food and Nutrition Service, USDA

§ 273.24, Nt.

number of exemptions in effect during the fiscal year does not exceed 12 percent of the number of covered individuals in the State, as estimated by FNS, based on FY 1996 quality control data and other factors FNS deems appropriate, and adjusted by FNS to reflect changes in:

- (i) The State agency's caseload; and
- (ii) FNS's estimate of changes in the proportion of SNAP recipients covered by waivers granted under paragraph (f) of this section.

(4) State agencies must not discriminate against any covered individual for reasons of age, race, color, sex, disability, religious creed, national origin, or political beliefs. Such discrimination is prohibited by this part, the Food and Nutrition Act of 2008, the Age Discrimination Act of 1975 (Public Law 94-135), the Rehabilitation Act of 1973 (Public Law 93-112, section 504), and title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 (42 U.S.C. 2000d). Enforcement action may be brought under any applicable Federal law. Title VI complaints will be processed in accord with 7 CFR part 15.

(h) *Adjustments.* FNS will make adjustments as follows:

(1) *Caseload adjustments.* FNS will adjust the number of exemptions estimated for a State agency under paragraph (g)(2) of this section during a fiscal year if the number of SNAP recipients in the State varies from the State's caseload by more than 10 percent, as estimated by FNS.

(2) *Exemption adjustments.* During each fiscal year, FNS will adjust the number of exemptions allocated to a State agency based on the number of exemptions in effect in the State for the preceding fiscal year.

(i) If the State agency does not use all of its exemptions by the end of the fiscal year, FNS will increase the estimated number of exemptions allocated to the State agency for the subsequent fiscal year by the remaining balance.

(ii) If the State agency exceeds its exemptions by the end of the fiscal year, FNS will reduce the estimated number of exemptions allocated to the State agency for the subsequent fiscal year by the corresponding number.

(i) *Reporting requirement.* The State agency will track the number of ex-

emptions used each month and report this number to the regional office on a quarterly basis as an addendum to the quarterly Employment and Training Report (Form FNS-583) required by § 273.7(c)(8).

(j) *Other Program rules.* Nothing in this section will make an individual eligible for SNAP benefits if the individual is not otherwise eligible for benefits under the other provisions of this part and the Food and Nutrition Act of 2008.

[Amdt. 379, 64 FR 48257, Sept. 3, 1999, as amended at 66 FR 4469, Jan. 17, 2001; 67 FR 41618, June 19, 2002; 71 FR 33384, June 9, 2006; 84 FR 66811, Dec. 5, 2019; 84 FR 66811, Dec. 5, 2020; 86 FR 410, Jan. 5, 2021; 86 FR 34605, June 30, 2021]

EFFECTIVE DATE NOTES: 1. At 89 FR 102362, Dec. 17, 2024, § 273.24 was amended by:

- a. Removing the number "50" and adding in its place "55" in paragraph (c)(1);
- b. Removing "or" from the end of paragraph (c)(5);
- c. Removing the period and adding a semicolon in its place in paragraph (c)(6);
- d. Adding paragraphs (c)(7) through (10);
- e. Removing the number "12" and adding in its place "8" in paragraph (g)(3);
- f. Adding a sentence at the end of paragraph (h)(2)(i); and
- g. Adding paragraphs (k) and (l).

The amendments are effective Jan. 16, 2025. For the convenience of the user, the added text is set forth as follows:

§ 273.24 Time limit for able-bodied adults.

* * * * *

(c) * * *

(7) Homeless, as defined in § 271.2 of this chapter;

(8) A veteran, defined as an individual who, regardless of the conditions of their discharge or release from, served in the United States Armed Forces (such as Army, Marine Corps, Navy, Air Force, Space Force, Coast Guard, and National Guard), including an individual who served in a reserve component of the Armed Forces, or served as a commissioned officer of the Public Health Service, Environmental Scientific Services Administration, or the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration; or

(9) An individual who is 24 years of age or younger and who was in foster care under the responsibility of any State, District, U.S. Territories, Indian Tribal Organization, or Unaccompanied Refugee Minors Program on the date of attaining 18 years of age, including those who remain in extended foster care in States that have elected to extend foster

§ 273.25

care in accordance with section 475(8)(B)(iii) of the Social Security Act (42 U.S.C. 675(8)(B)(iii)) or those who leave extended foster care before the maximum age.

(10) Unless otherwise changed by law, the exceptions provided at paragraphs (c)(7) through (9) of this section cease to have effect on October 1, 2030, and the age limit provided in paragraph (c)(1) of this section reverts from “55 years of age or older” to “50 years of age or older” on October 1, 2030.

* * * * *

(h) * * *

(2) * * *

(i) * * * Starting in FY 2026, FNS will increase the estimated number of exemptions allocated to the State agency for the subsequent fiscal year by the remaining balance of unused exemptions earned for the previous fiscal year. FNS will consider the State agency to use exemptions in order of accrual (first-in, first-out) for the purposes of calculating carryover of unused exemptions.

* * * * *

(k) *Screening.* The State agency must screen individuals for all exceptions from the time limit listed under paragraph (c) of this section at certification and recertification. The State agency must not assign countable months unless it has screened the individual and determined that no exception applies. When an individual qualifies for more than one exception, the State agency must apply the exception that will be in effect the longest.

(1) Changes in exception status during the certification period.

(i) *Loss of an exception.* If during the certification period an individual has a change in circumstances that results in the loss of an exception from the time limit, the State agency cannot begin assigning countable months until it screens the individual to determine whether any other exception applies.

(ii) *Newly meeting an exception.* If during the certification period an individual subject to the time limit has a change in circumstance that results in the individual now meeting an exception, the State agency must act promptly to apply the exception and cannot assign a countable month once the State receives information that is not questionable. If the State agency determines the information is questionable, the State agency must act promptly to verify the information in accordance with paragraph (1) of this section. Once verified, the State agency must apply the exception and cannot assign countable months.

(l) *Verification of exceptions.* If the State agency determines an individual's exception status under paragraph (c) of this section is

7 CFR Ch. II (1–1–25 Edition)

questionable, the State agency must first attempt to verify exception status using information available to the State agency, such as information from other public assistance programs through data sharing, before requiring individuals provide documentary evidence or other sources of verification.

2. At 89 FR 90569, Nov. 18, 2024, § 273.24 was further amended by adding paragraph (a)(4), effective Jan. 17, 2025. For the convenience of the user, the added text is set forth as follows:

§ 273.24 Time limit for able-bodied adults.

(a) * * *

(4) *Workfare program* means:

(i) A program under § 273.7(m); or

(ii) A comparable program established by a State or political subdivision of a State.

* * * * *

§ 273.25 Simplified SNAP.

(a) *Definitions.* For purposes of this section:

(1) Simplified SNAP (S-SNAP) means a program authorized under 7 U.S.C. 2035.

(2) Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) means a State program of family assistance operated by an eligible State under its TANF plan as defined at 45 CFR 260.30.

(3) Pure-TANF household means a household in which all members receive assistance under a State program funded under part A of title IV of the Social Security Act (42 U.S.C. 601 *et seq.*).

(4) Mixed-TANF household means a household in which 1 or more members, but not all members, receive assistance under a State program funded under part A of title IV of the Social Security Act (42 U.S.C. 601 *et seq.*).

(5) Assistance under a State program funded under part A of title IV of the Social Security Act (42 U.S.C. 601 *et seq.*) means “assistance” as defined in regulations at 45 CFR 260.31.

(b) *Limit on benefit reduction for mixed-TANF households under the S-SNAP.* If a State agency chooses to operate an S-SNAP and includes mixed-TANF households in its program, the following requirements apply in addition to the statutory requirements governing the S-SNAP.

(1) If a State's S-SNAP reduces benefits for mixed-TANF households, then